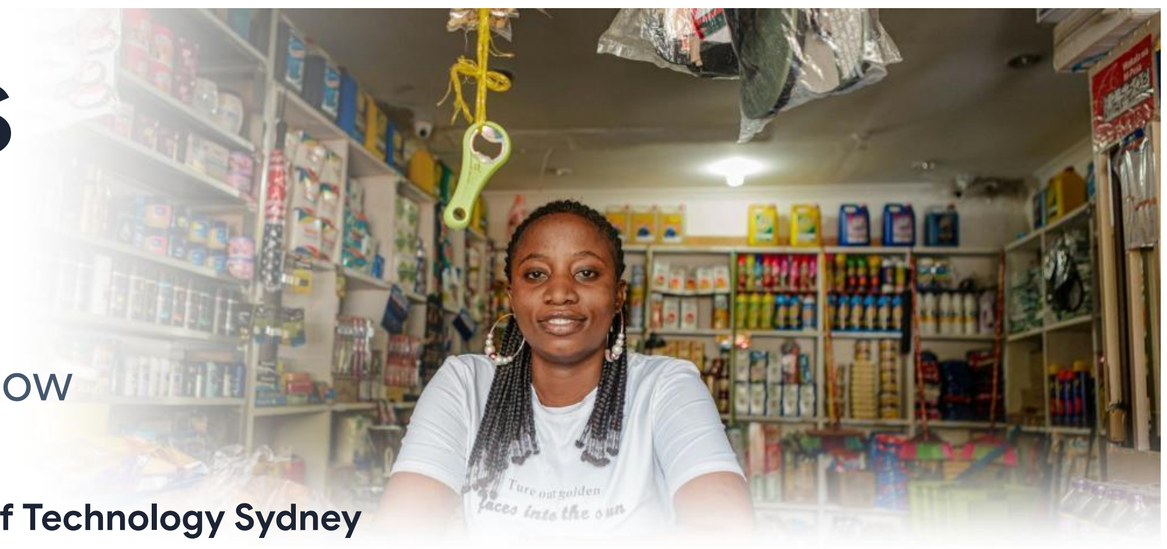
UNSW MARKETING ANALYTICS HACKATHON 2026 · FINALIST

Getting slow loans funded faster

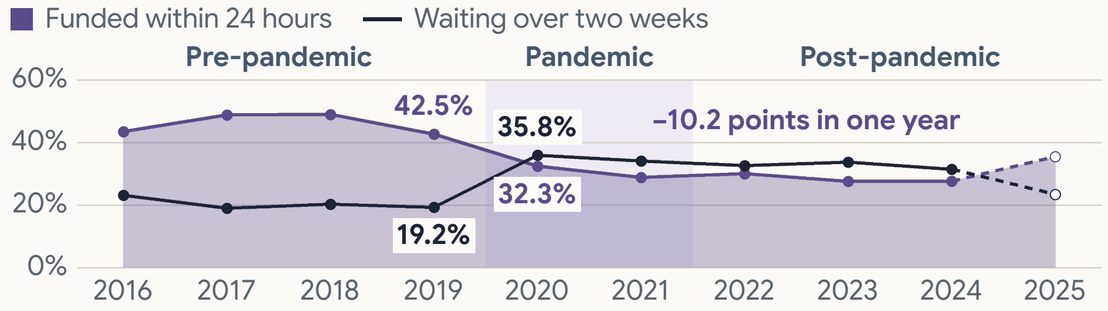


What 1.45 million Kiva loans say about predicting slow loans and supporting them

Mike Nguyen and Sophia Nguyen, Team Cultural Blend, University of Technology Sydney

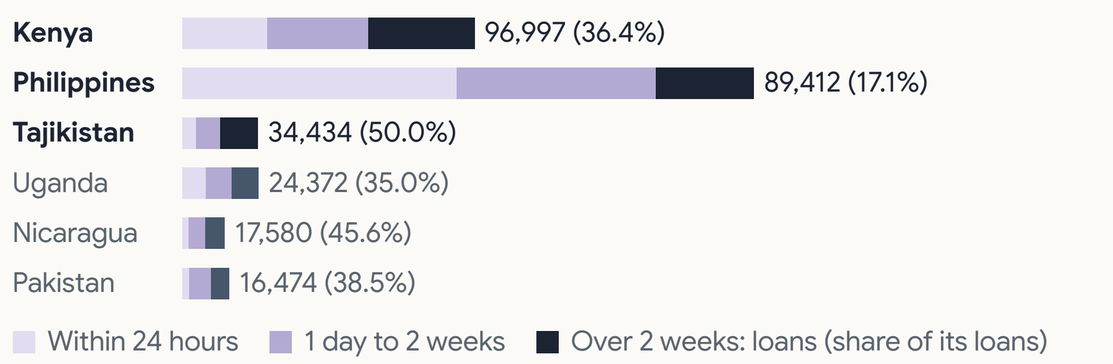
PROBLEM

Waits got longer after 2019: a third of loans now wait over two weeks



Open markers: 2025 may be incomplete.

Over half of all two-week waits come from just three countries

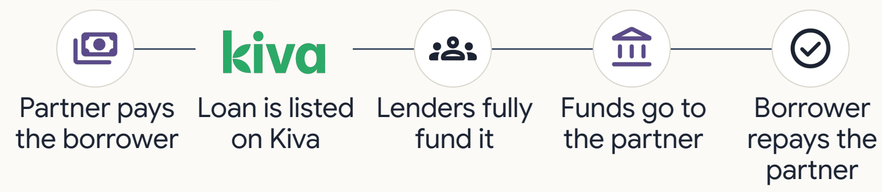


EVIDENCE

Borrowers usually have the money before lenders fund the loan

Borrower has the money: **median 24.2 days**

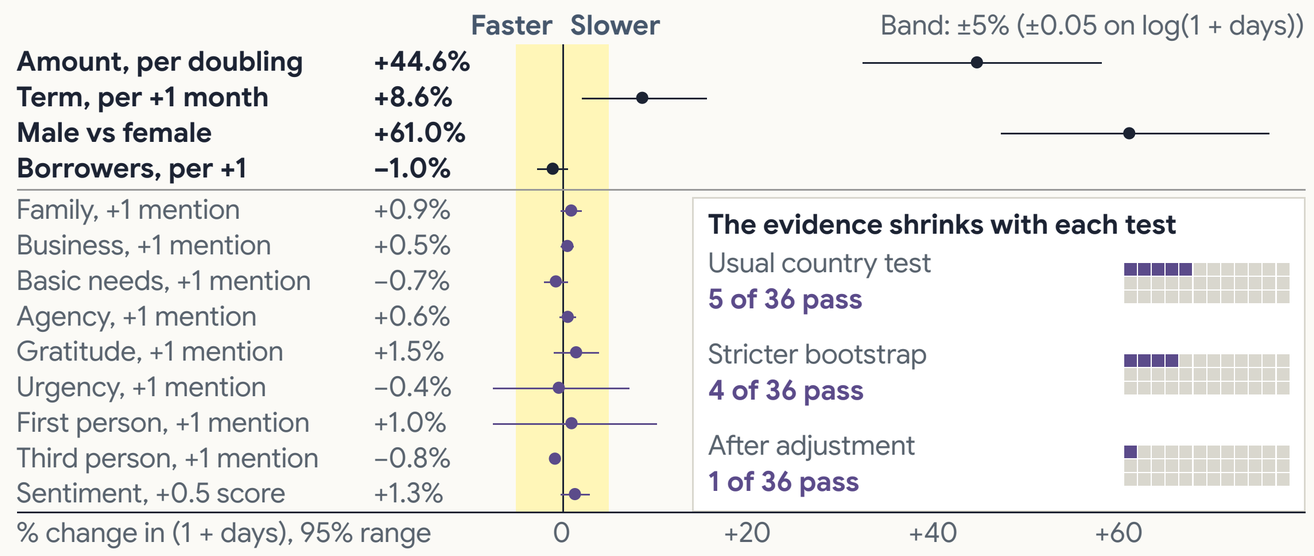
We measure: **median 2.85 days**



96.4% of loans reach the borrower before listing

Only **3.6%** are paid out after listing, so slow funding mainly holds up the partner's next loans.

Slow funding is a lender-side delay that loan details predict, not wording



One tiny signal passes the strictest test, but not with programme controls.

SOLUTION

Our solution: predict slow loans, prioritise support, test before advising

Step	What	How	Status
Predict	Score each listing's **risk of slow funding** when it is posted.	A boosted tree on loan structure; text adds little to this score.	**Retrospective check only**
Prioritise	Send **lender-side support** to flagged loans.	Featuring, matching funds, lender alerts and partner follow-up.	**Needs a pilot**
Test	Earn the right to give **writing advice**.	Pass three gates before any advice.	**Not started**

A flag at listing beats a simple historical lookup in every year

2.6–4.0× as many of the slowest fifth as a random pick, funded loans only



The gap's 95% range is **above zero every year**. Median within-country precision: **0.49–0.56** vs 0.22–0.29 for the lookup (random 0.20).

NEXT STEPS

Four limits decide what the solution can claim today

Associations, not causes
Pilot each lever and prompt **against a control**.

Funded loans only
Add **expired listings** before judging reach.

Uneven across countries
Recalibrate and validate the flag **country by country**.

For whom and when
Treat **weak signals** as hypotheses to test.

Flag slow loans first.
Earn writing advice last.

OUR ASK TO KIVA

NOW **One partner** to pilot the flag

NEXT **Expired listings** and **country data**

LATER A partner for **one prompt pilot**

393,847
27.1% of all loans waited over two weeks